

Ashen

The Mad Alchemist - A one-shot

Player Packet

THE JOB



“Seventeen gone since the thaw. The Reeve stopped writing the names down after the ninth — said it was bad for morale. I keep my own list.”

The present document is a player’s primer to the Ashen learn-to-play adventure you are about to play. While you are welcome to, you do not need to read the rulebook, and you do not need to make a character. This packet includes seven pre-generated characters. You can use them as they come, change names or details, or even, if none appeals, make your own. Discuss with the GM to make sure your character fits with the parameters of the adventure.

This packet has three parts: this page, a short **How to Play**, and a **profile** for each of the seven characters. Read this page, skim your profile, and let the rules find you at the table.

THE WORLD IN FIVE LINES

The Last War ended and nobody won. The gods are dead, dying, or hiding. What remains of the world is wrapped in **the Fog**: a roiling magical haze that rots minds, warps machines, and makes travel a hazard rather than a chore.

People survive in **Clears**: pockets of thin Fog where crops grow and lungs work. Between the Clears are ruins, wilderness, and the leftovers of a war fought with magic and industry at the same time.

This is not to say that civilization is entirely nonexistent outside of the Clears: the **Fogborn**, men adapted to the strange environment outside, and some of the Deathless make their home there. But life is harder, people are fewer, and whosoever would dwell in the Fog must be prepared to reckon with it.

YOU ARE DEATHLESS

You died in the Last War. You did not stay dead.

You are one of the **Deathless**: an immortal veteran bound to the world until whatever holds you here is finished. You remember only fragments: a face, perhaps, or the feeling that someone, somewhere, owes you something — and not much else. Ordinary people, insofar as anyone in this shattered world can be said to be normal, find you useful, valuable, and a little frightening.

When you drop to 0 HP, you die. Then you get up again. You can spend **Essence** to come back on the spot, or your soul returns to its anchor and you reincorporate somewhere else, later.

For you, death is not the end, but die too much and you’ll be out of the fight for a good couple of days at least. Plenty of time to make a getaway or beef up defenses.

THE CONTRACT

The **Never-Still**, dreamers pledged to long-lost deities of the Faerie Realms, hold a share of **Venna Weald**, a large Clear in the northwestern forests of the one remaining continent. Old fey sites make the region valuable to them.

People around **Keshto Village**, a frontier settlement on the Weald’s edge, have been disappearing. First foragers and travellers. Then two of the Never-Still’s own peacekeepers. The disappearances are speeding up, and nobody local can explain them.

So the Never-Still posted a **Black Guard contract** — the closest thing the Deathless have to a neutral, enforceable job offer — for anyone willing to go and find out why.

You took it.

WHY YOU ARE HERE

Each premade character's profile names a reason for their participation. If you'd like to change it, or make your own character, here are the three broad reasons why anyone would pledge their name at the Black Bazaar.

- **Faction business.** You aren't here so much by choice as obligation. Someone above you wants this handled, or wants eyes on it.
- **The coin.** Black Guard contracts pay, and finishing one builds a name that gets you the next one.
- **Something personal.** There's something about these events that touches on business you have not finished with.

YOUR OBJECTIVE

Find out what is taking people, where it's taking them, and stop it.

Sounds simple — but if it were trivial, the authorities of the Weald would have dealt with it already. Be prepared to have to earn your pay, by hook, crook, or force.

HOW TO PLAY



The following pages detail everything you need to play. Of course, many small rules have been left out of this overview. If anything is unclear at the table, feel free to ask the GM.

WHAT YOU NEED TO PLAY

To play, you'll need your character sheet, your wits about you, some scratch paper, a pen, and a collection of dice. Ashen principally uses normal six-sided dice, abbreviated "d6" or "d". For certain features of the game, like damage calculation, other dice with sides from 4 to 12 are used. It is recommended that each player have 10 six-sided dice and one d4, d8, d10 and d12 each.

THE BASIC CONVERSATION

Like every other Tabletop RPG, the core of gameplay is nothing more than a conversation. The game unfolds as follows:

1. The GM describes the situation.
2. You say what your character does.
3. If the outcome is obvious, it just happens.
4. If success and failure are both plausible **and both interesting**, you roll.

Then repeat.

CHECKS AND ASHEN DICE

When the outcome of a character's action is in doubt, the GM will call to make a **check**. When this happens, the GM will also announce what skill or characteristic you will need to check against. On your character sheet, find the **rating** for that statistic — the right-most number for each skill or characteristic — and roll as many six-sided dice as that number.

Then count the results. Each side of each die is worth a certain number of **successes**:

READING ASHEN DICE

Die result	Contribution
1	-1 success
2-3	no successes
4-5	1 success
6	2 successes

Add it up. Meet or beat the **difficulty** and you succeed. Come in under it and you fail. Land on zero or below and you have scored a **critical failure** — something has actively gone wrong, not merely not-worked.

Difficulty 3 is a real task competently attempted. Difficulty 5 is hard. Difficulty 7 is something you should have prepared for.

Example: Your Awareness rating is 5, so you roll 5d to notice a tripwire. You get 6, 4, 3, 2, 1. That is $2 + 1 + 0 + 0 - 1 = 2$ **successes**. Against difficulty 2 you spot it. Against difficulty 3 you do not.

Bonuses and penalties

Bonuses and penalties change **how many dice you pick up**. A +2d bonus means two extra dice. A -2d penalty means two fewer. If penalties would take you to zero dice, you simply fail; there is nothing to roll.

Bonuses and penalties may be **situational** or **innate**. Innate bonuses are listed on your character sheet; situational ones are communicated to you by the GM.

Example: a human with the **Pistoleer** advance fires their pistol at an enemy in a cramped basement. They fire at close range, so their advance gives them an **innate bonus** of two dice; but it is dark in the basement, so the GM rules that they also take a **-2d situational penalty** to the attack. The end result is that both cancel out and the character just rolls their Marksmanship as normal.

READING YOUR SHEET

Your sheet is filled in already. These are the boxes you will actually touch:

THE NUMBERS YOU NEED

Box	What it does
HP	Hit points. At 0 you die (see below).
FP	Focus. Fuel for powers, spells, and special attacks.
EP	Essence. Spend 5 to get back up after dying.
AP	Action points — 4 per turn.
Evasion	How many successes an attacker needs to hit you.
Armor	Subtracted from incoming physical damage.
Ward	Subtracted from incoming magical damage.
Move	Squares you cross with one Move action.
Ratings	Your dice pools. Bigger is better; roll that many d6.

Everything else on the sheet is reference material for a longer campaign. Ignore it today.

WHAT THE RATINGS MEAN

Your ratings come in two groups. **Characteristics** cover fighting and resisting harm; **skills** cover everything else. Both are rolled the same way: the total rating = the number of dice you throw.

CHARACTERISTICS

Characteristic	Roll it to...
Martial	Attack with melee and thrown weapons; resist being overpowered.
Marksmanship	Attack with ranged weapons.
Initiative	Determine turn order; react to surprises and sudden dangers.
Speed	Cover ground under time pressure. Also sets your Move.
Stamina	Resist poison, disease, and fatigue. Also sets how much you can carry.
Potential	Resist harmful magic. Also sets how much magical equipment you can bear.
Arcane	Cast arcane spells.
Psychic	Use psychic powers.
Command	Use command powers and divine prayers.
Dodge	Avoid area attacks and effects. Also sets your Evasion.
Grit	Resist pain, fear, and mental influence.

SKILLS

Skill	Roll it to...
Acrobatics	Keep your balance, tumble, contort, land safely.
Athletics	Climb, jump, swim, lift; feats of strength.
Awareness	Notice threats and details in your surroundings.
Deceive	Lie convincingly.
Eerie	Use your sixth sense: detect magic, hidden danger, false motives.
Impose	Get your way through intimidation.
Influence	Get your way through persuasion.
Investigate	Research, deduce, search methodically.
Subterfuge	Sneak, hide, steal, cheat.
Access [†]	Bypass locks, security systems, and barriers.
Alchemy [†]	Identify and prepare chemical and alchemical substances.
Electronics [†]	Operate, repair, and subvert electronic devices.
Magitek [†]	Understand and operate magical technology.
Occultism [†]	Deal with spirits and objects a supernatural presence inhabits.
Piloting [†]	Control high-speed vehicles.
Ritual [†]	Perform invocations and other long-form magic.
Shop [†]	Weld, rivet, lathe, repair machinery.

Skills marked [†] are **trained**: no matter what your total rating would be, if the skill is not checked on your sheet, you cannot attempt it at all. Everything else can always be rolled.

COMBAT

Unless you are exceptionally clever, it is likely you will find yourself in combat at some point during the adventure. Combat uses a slightly more granular resolution system than normal play: each combatant gets one turn per round; each turn you get **4 AP** to spend.

Rolling initiative

To determine your place in the turn order, roll a number of d6 equal to your **Initiative rating** when combat starts. Unlike all other such rolls, here you add the **pips** — the actual numbers on the dice, not successes. Highest goes first.

Spending AP

COMMON ACTIONS

AP	What you can do
1	Take Aim, Brace, Disengage, Draw or stash an item, Stand up
2	Attack , Dash, Use an item, Combat maneuver, most powers
3	Charge (move at a target, then attack with +4d)
Varies	Move, use a skill, use a power

Move actions are special: Your **first** Move each turn costs 1 AP. Your second costs 2, your third costs 3 and so on, though in practice it is very rare for a character to ever be in a position to move three times per turn.

Making an attack

1. Pick a target in range.
2. Roll **Martial** for melee, **Marksmanship** for ranged, or whatever the power tells you.
3. Successes equal to or greater than the target's **Evasion** means you hit. If the number of successes greatly exceeds the target's Evasion, you may hit multiple times.
4. For each hit: Roll the weapon's damage.
5. Subtract the target's Armor (physical) or Ward (magical). **Penetration** on your weapon cancels that much Armor.
6. What is left comes off their HP.

Combat Maneuvers

Instead of making an attack, you may also perform a Combat Maneuver. This is a catch-all term for an action in melee that consists of more than striking with your weapon for damage. Some examples of combat maneuvers include:

- throwing sand into an enemy's eyes to distract them
- using the haft of your polearm to trip an opponent
- shooting a weapon out of someone's hand with your pistol
- cutting off a part of a dragon's wing to prevent it from flying

To perform a maneuver, describe what you are trying to do to the GM. The GM decides whether the maneuver is achievable and if so, at what

penalty you roll. If your attack roll hits the target after the penalty is applied, your maneuver takes effect. As for attacks, the more successes, the better the result.

If the maneuver involves striking the target with a weapon, it deals damage, but never inflicts more than one hit. Excess successes convert into a better result on the maneuver instead.

Reactions

In addition to the actions your character has on each turn, they may also take reactions. You get **one reaction per round**.

Reactions obey a certain number of special rules:

- A reaction must be triggered by another action to be performed
- You may never take a reaction on your own turn

There are five reactions each character always has access to:

UNIVERSAL REACTIONS

Reaction	Trigger	Effect
Opportunity Attack	An enemy leaves your melee range or attacks outside of it while in it	You make a strike against the target
Dive	You are targeted by an Area effect or power	You roll out of the area
Counter-spell	Another creature casts a magical power of a type you can cast	You counter it with your own magic
Fire Over-watch	Another creature charges you	You can fire a ranged weapon at it
Reactive Maneuver	Nearly anything	You interfere with the enemy somehow

Reactive Maneuvers include things like parries or trips.

Damage, and dying

At 0 HP you die. On your next turn you may spend **5 EP (Essence Points)** to get straight back up, provided your body is still in one piece. If you cannot or will not, your essence goes home to your soul anchor and you are out of the fight

Enemies that understand what you are may try to damage your dead body in order to prevent your revival on the spot.

Powers

Some characters have **powers**: supernatural abilities they can use in combat in lieu of a more mundane action. Powers can have a dizzying array of effects; each Power's description explains exactly what it does. Powers cost **Focus**, or **FP** for short.

Powers generally require some sort of implement to use, either a weapon or a magical focus called a **Catalyst**. The cost of these powers are given in **increments** of Focus. The increment is a property of the implement used to manifest the power.

Example: Flamethrower is an Arcane Spell that costs 1 Increment of focus; the Increment of a **Mist Capacitor** is 8, so casting this spell with that catalyst costs 8 Focus.

The exception are **innate powers**, which have a flat FP cost.

Resting and Recovery

If you've been in a fight, you are likely to be injured, or have spent all your Focus. If you were a mortal man (or woman), this would likely require weeks of resting and recovery to heal — but you are Deathless. You may spend EP to activate your immortal body's prodigious healing ability. With one EP spent, you may recover up to half your Health or your entire Focus.

While this ability is much faster than a mortal's natural healing, it does still require a bit of time. You need around half an hour of rest to use this ability, so you cannot do it while you're still fighting.

Many more detailed rules are deliberately left out of this primer, but that is what a learn-to-play adventure is about. Describe what you want, and let the GM translate.

CHARACTER PROFILES



CHARACTER OVERVIEW

Name	Kind	Does what	Fiddly?
Ushtang	Warboar	Hits things until they stop	No
Zamazaha	Porcelain	Duels, dances, punishes misses	A little
Pahak	Ironhands	Carries the machine gun	No
Kalariyar	Shade	Scouts, teleports, freezes	Some
Wishanya	Porcelain	Sets the room on fire	Some
Kho Prea	Human	Heals, blesses, saves rolls	Some
Mbazan	Goldenbristle	Gives orders, slows enemies	Most

The following pages introduce seven ready-to-play characters. Every one of them is built to the same budget, so no single one is stronger than the others, but every character is good at different things.

As combat is the most complex part of the game, each character comes with a more detailed explanation of what they can do in combat and how to play them in a fight.

The names given to these playtest characters aren't set in stone: if you'd prefer to play Juan the Warboar to Ushtang the warboar, or make any other modifications, that is perfectly possible. For this reason, too, while ideally every player would pick a different character, if more than one person prefers to play the same character, then that character can simply be made into two with a name change and perhaps one or two minor tweaks.

USHTANG

FRONT LINE

Warboar Sootbeast — *Never-Still*, by way of a friend

"Usually when I go looking for someone it's just business. This time it's quite personal."



HP 19 • FP 11 • EP 11 • Evasion 0 • Armor 6 • Ward 2 • Move 7

WHO YOU ARE

One of the peacekeepers who vanished outside Keshto was a friend. He was mortal, and so your friendship was always destined to end, but you are incensed at the way it did. The concerns of the Never-Still are not your concerns; you only came because somebody took something of yours, and you intend to make sure that the responsible parties are made to understand their transgressions.

You are the largest, toughest member of the party, but you have no magic whatsoever. You have, so far, found that you do not need it.

WHAT YOU'RE GOOD AT

- **Hitting things.** Your Martial stat is 7 — the best melee pool in the party.
- **Not dying.** 19 HP, Armor 6, Ward 2. You are not going down any time soon.
- **Momentum. Tide of Iron:** every kill hands you back up to 2 AP, so a good turn keeps going.
- **Refusing to move.** +2 against anything that would shove, pull, or drag you, and +2 when you do it to someone else.
- **Courage.** As a Warboar, you are simply immune to fear. A privilege when combined with immortality.
- **Staying in.** Once per fight, 1 AP heals you and clears all ongoing damage.
- **Dealing with terrain.** You have trained your body well. You have Athletics 7, Acrobatics 6. Climb it, jump it, break it.

WHAT YOU SHOULD WATCH FOR

- **Evasion 0.** Everything hits you. The armor helps, but it won't absorb everything.
- **Range.** You have Marksmanship 3 and a hammer. If the fight is at a distance you are doing some walking.
- **Poison.** Sootbeast flesh takes 50% extra poison damage and resists disease at +2 difficulty. Do not drink the strange liquid.

COMBAT TACTICS

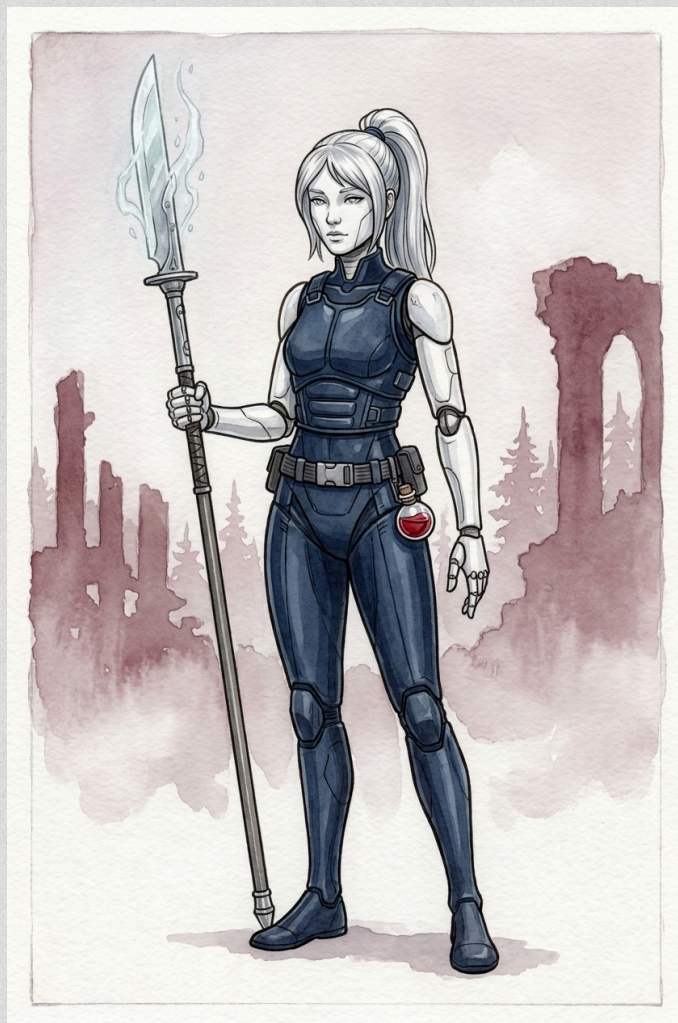
Charge — 3 AP, move at the nearest enemy, attack with +4d. That is **11 dice** on your opening swing. If the charge kills, Tide of Iron refunds up to 2 AP and you go again. Simple, but effective.

ZAMAZAHA

FRONT LINE

Porcelain Clockwork — A free agent, building her name

"I was made to pour tea. What excuse do you have?"



HP 16 · FP 13 · EP 11 · Evasion 4 · Armor 5 · Ward 0 · Move 7

WHO YOU ARE

The Porcelains, it is said, were meant to be their Goddess' playmates, before they were repurposed as tools of war. In your case, you awoke with an encyclopaedic knowledge of tea ceremony and a bladed weapon in your hands. Finding little use for the former, you ended up making your living with the latter.

As a free agent, you take whatever contract pleases you. The ones with large amounts of feathers attached please you the most.

WHAT YOU'RE GOOD AT

- **Reaching and cutting.** Your weapon is a Force Glaive, 7+d6, **Penetration 2**, hits at 2 squares.
- **Moving.** Your Move 7 is tied for the fastest in the party. Your **Vault** advance and **Graceful Form** trait let you walk through enemy squares as though they weren't there.
- **Punishing misses.** When an enemy misses you in melee, you can hit them back with your **Riposte** before their turn is done.
- **Not being hit.** Your Evasion of 4 make you able to dodge many attacks, and Armor 5 isn't bad either.
- **Sensing magic.** Your ancestry gives you Magicsense out to 10m, and a bonus +1d on Eerie checks about arcane effects to boot.

WHAT YOU SHOULD WATCH FOR

- **Magic.** Your ability to resist magic is very low; try to get your friends to distract any spellcasters.
- **The Fog.** Clockworks suffer at half the usual exposure thresholds, and Dense Fog can make you malfunction outright.
- **Magnets and grit.** Strong magnetic fields and airborne particulates both give you stacking penalties.
- **Questions.** You have Deceive 3. You are honest largely by construction.

COMBAT TACTICS

Use 1 AP to move into reach at 2 squares, then 2 AP for **Measured Strike** (4 FP): full damage **and** +2 Evasion until your next turn: you swing first, and if the enemy attempts to hit back, you are likely to evade and **Riposte**. At 13 FP you can do this three times before you run out.

Ironhands Clockwork — *On the Perfector's' secret service*

"My orders are to observe and report. I have found that observation goes better with covering fire."



HP 17 • FP 12 • EP 11 • Evasion 0 • Armor 6 • Ward 1 • Move 6

WHO YOU ARE

You are an agent of the Perfectors, that ancient order of gearsmiths pledged to the memory of Third, Mother-Goddess of arcane magic and machinery. They sent you to Keshto with instructions that are slightly vaguer than you would like. Something about the disappearances interests them, but your superior did not deign to share the details with you. Perhaps his superior hadn't either.

As far as your teammates are concerned, though, you are mostly a weapons platform with legs. Your job is to make the range between the party and the enemy expensive to cross.

WHAT YOU'RE GOOD AT

- **Volume.** Your weapon is a Perfector Gatling Mk IV: 8+d8 at Long range, firing full auto from Marksmanship 6.
- **Absorbing.** You're not quite as heavy as the Warboar, but you have 17 HP behind Armor 6 and Ward 1.
- **Seeing through walls.** Your nature grants you Electroception out to 10m — you sense powered and magnetic things through solid obstacles.
- **Shooting and scooting.** With your **Gun and Run** power (5 FP, 2 uses), you can move up to half your Speed **as part of** an attack, for full damage.
- **Getting in.** You have Access 6 and Shop 5 — the party's best at locks, doors, and systems. And if brute strength is necessary, your Athletics rating is 6.

WHAT YOU SHOULD WATCH FOR

- **Evasion 0.** Your frame is not dodging anything. Use cover instead.
- **A lack of stealth.** Your Subterfuge is only 3, and you weigh several hundred kilos. You are, in all likelihood, the reason the plan gets loud.
- **Fog, magnets, dust.** All three degrade you, and Fog affects you at half the normal thresholds.
- **Nuance.** Deceive 3, Eerie 3, Investigate 4 — if you expect to have to lie, or be lied to, you'll want backup.

COMBAT TACTICS

1 AP **Take Aim**, then 2 AP to fire the gatling at the largest threat you can see — full auto, 7d to hit. Keep the last AP for a reaction-free reposition. If you need to change position and still shoot, use **Gun and Run** instead and do both for 2 AP.

Shade Echo — *On personal business*

"The old sites remember me. I would rather find out why before somebody else does."



HP 14 · FP 13 · EP 11 · Evasion 4 · Armor 4 · Ward 0 · Move 6

WHO YOU ARE

You are a Shade; an erstwhile denizen of the realms of Faerie, and companion of the Midnight Princess. Shades hunted the long winter nights of Faerie for the Goddess of what is Hidden and Forgotten, and you have kept the instinct, if not the memory.

The fey sites around Venna Weald are your best chance at remembering something of your past. Somebody is killing people next to them, and you want to know whether that is coincidence.

WHAT YOU'RE GOOD AT

- **Noticing.** You have an Awareness of 7, the best in the party by two. Your Shade ancestry grants you Blindsense out to 5m: you detect things by sound with no line of sight at all.
- **Dealing with armor.** Your Cryo Pistol has **Penetration 4**, far and away the party's best answer to a heavily armored target. Even better, every hit forces a Stamina check; failure means **Slowed**, and hitting an already-Slowed target **Freezes** it outright.
- **Point blank.** **Pistoleer** gives +2d at 3 squares or less (**7 dice**), and **CQB Specialist** means shooting inside melee does not provoke.
- **Going where you like.** **Fey Jaunt** (6 FP): teleport anywhere within your move range, as a move.

WHAT YOU SHOULD WATCH FOR

- **Daylight.** You take -1d on Perception checks and attack rolls in direct sunlight. You are a night and interior operator.
- **Being hit.** You're a bit more fragile than some others. Evasion 4 is good, but cover is also your friend.
- **Physical exertion.** At Strength 1 and Endurance 1, brawn is not your forte.

COMBAT TACTICS

You have a signature move: use 2 AP for **Hunt of the Autumn Court** (6 FP) to mark an enemy within 15 — your shots then ignore its cover and concealment — then 2 AP to shoot it. Later, **Fey Jaunt** can drop you **adjacent to the mark at any distance**, which is how you reach the enemy's back line. You have Focus for two innate powers per scene, so choose wisely when to make use of it.

Porcelain Clockwork — *Following the method*

"Whoever is doing this knows what they're doing. That makes it predictable."



HP 13 · FP 16 · EP 11 · Evasion 3 · Armor 4 · Ward 0 · Move 5

WHO YOU ARE

Just-So, Goddess of Magic, built the Porcelains as conduits for raw magical force. You went further on your own initiative: you read voraciously; Alchemy, Ritual, Magitek, whatever survived the war in a condition worth reading.

You took this contract because the little you have heard about the disappearances sounds methodical, and methodical means a practitioner. You would quite like to see their notes.

WHAT YOU'RE GOOD AT

- **Area damage.** Your **Flamethrower** is an 11 meter Cone of Thermal damage (8+d4) plus 3 ongoing burn that lasts until saved against.
- **Dealing with magic.** Your Porcelain ancestry gives you Magicsense to 10m and a bonus to your Eerie checks; your Skills mean you have an easy time researching and understanding magical workings.
- **Free Focus.** Your **Spell Capacitor** lets you roll a d6 every time you spend Focus, on a 5 or 6 you get it all back.

WHAT YOU SHOULD WATCH FOR

- **Friendly fire.** A Cone 11 is enormous. Be careful not to burn the rest of the party.
- **Melee.** Between your magic and your pistol, you prefer staying at range.
- **Fog and magnets.** The frailties of every Clockwork.

COMBAT TACTICS

Wait for two enemies to line up, then 2 AP **Flamethrower** (8 FP): Cone 11, difficulty 3, resisted by each target's Dodge against your cast. Full Thermal damage plus 3 ongoing. You have Focus for **two** casts — more if Spell Capacitor is kind — so the first one should catch at least two targets.

KHO PREA

DIVINE SUPPORT

Human — *Sent by the Children of the Flame*

"The Clear is thinning at the western edge. Nobody in Keshto has mentioned it. I find that interesting."



HP 15 · FP 15 · EP 11 · Evasion 2 · Armor 2 · Ward 4 · Move 6

WHO YOU ARE

Humans were adopted by the Sun God Kharu when their own mother turned on them. You have elected to show your appreciation for this inheritance. The Children of the Flame keep the Clears alive; when this one started showing signs of destabilizing, you were sent to keep an eye on it. All the easier to do so if the cause might be a person.

You carry with you an ember of the Sun-God's flame, light and warmth unto the wretched; you also carry a gun, for the especially wretched.

WHAT YOU'RE GOOD AT

- **Healing. Mend Wounds** (5 FP, 3 casts) is your staple prayer. An ally within 15 squares of you recovers 4+d3 HP. **Tap** it to double that. At Command 7, you have a very good chance of the God-Shard coming to your aid.
- **Strengthening your allies.** With **Sunfire Blessing**, an ally's weapon gains half your damage roll as bonus Thermal damage, and when tapped, the full roll.
- **Rescuing any roll.** Your Human ancestry comes with the **Gift of the Sun**: spend 2 EP to add **2 automatic successes to any check**. And you decide **after seeing the dice!**
- **Free taps. Golden Apple:** you start attuned with 1 favor, and the first tap each encounter costs nothing.
- **Ward 4.** The best magical defence in the party.
- **Being an all-rounder out of combat.** Investigate 6, Ritual 6, Deceive 6, Athletics 6, Alchemy 5. You have a lot of useful skills in a lot of domains.

WHAT YOU SHOULD WATCH FOR

- **Physical attacks.** At Armor and Evasion 2, both gun and sword land and hurt. Keep something between you and them.
- **Hostile magic.** Your **Gift of the Earth** cuts both ways: your buffs last two rounds longer, but your saves against hostile magic need 3 successes instead of 2.
- **Being the only healer.** Everyone else has at most a potion. Your magic may come in more than handy.

COMBAT TACTICS

Open with **Sunfire Blessing** on whoever is about to swing hardest, for 2 AP and 5 FP; tap it for free because it is your first tap this encounter. You can spend 2 AP to shoot, or move to reposition. You'll probably want to keep 5 FP in reserve at all times; those are cheaper than a death.

Goldenbristle Sootbeast — *The most directly concerned*

"I have lost patrols before. I have never lost them quietly. That is what is wrong here."



HP 13 · FP 17 · EP 11 · Evasion 2 · Armor 2 · Ward 4 · Move 5

WHO YOU ARE

Goldenbristles were bred as the field commanders of Sootbeast armies, and the Never-Still gave you a real command to go with the instinct. You are in charge of policing in a different village; when Keshto began losing patrols, you applied to come and help — better solve this problem here, before it's your men on the line.

You don't fight that well on your own, but that's fine. Every team needs at least one team player.

WHAT YOU'RE GOOD AT

- **Talking.** You have Influence 7 — the best in the party, and a respectable Impose 6. You are good at dealing with anyone who needs to be convinced, one way or the other.
- **Command powers.** With **Rally** (4 FP), an ally within 10 meters gets +2 on their next attack or resistance check, and may immediately shake off fear. **Born Leader** gives +2 on the roll to activate it.
- **Breaking tempo.** You're not just a leader of men, but a psychic to boot — with **Slow** (5 FP, 3 casts), a target within 12 loses Movement Speed and Initiative if it fails its Potential check.
- **Owning the initiative.** As a Goldenbristle, you get +2 dice to your Initiative roll, and **once per round you may swap places in the initiative order with any ally you can see.** With judicious use of this ability, the battle is yours to control. 1 AP.
- **Facing Magic.** With 4 Ward, you're tied for best magic resist in the party.

WHAT YOU SHOULD WATCH FOR

- **Physical Attacks.** With 13 HP and 2 Armor, you have the least ability to absorb damage, in one package with rather middling dodging ability.
- **Missing.** You have both Martial and Marksmanship at 3. The rifle shouldn't be your first choice.
- **Poisons.** Your Sootbeast ancestry makes you vulnerable to Chemical damage.

COMBAT TACTICS

Before you do anything, look at the initiative order and consider swapping with whoever is badly placed — it is free and it is once per round. Then 2 AP **Rally** on the ally about to make the important attack, or 2 AP **Slow** on whatever is closing on your casters. You have Focus for roughly three casts plus Rallies, and 17 FP is the largest pool in the party.